

## Exercise 27: Cryptic Cluster (Characteristics of Admired Leaders)

- A cryptic cluster puzzle is a list of items that belong to the same category. The items are enciphered with a substitution code in which every letter of the alphabet is consistently replaced by another letter.
- Here's a list of 11 characteristics of admired leaders from *The Leadership Challenge* by James M. Kouzes & Barry Z. Posner (published by Jossey-Bass © 2003. ISBN 0787968331). Can you solve the puzzle and identify all the characteristics?

|             |                 |                 |
|-------------|-----------------|-----------------|
| OWZHJS      | DWBRFBQ-UWWYCZI | CZJXCBCZI       |
| PWAXHSHZS   | DFCB-ACZQH      | JNXXWBSCMH      |
| KBWFQ-ACZQH | CZSHUUCIHZS     | JSBFCIOSDWBRFBQ |
| QHXHZQFKUH  | PWNBFIHWNJ      |                 |

### How to Solve Cryptic Clusters:

- The most commonly used letters of the English language are e, t, a, i, o, n, s, h, and r. Find the most-frequently occurring letters in the cryptic cluster list and try substituting these letters.
- The letters that are most commonly found at the beginnings of words are t, a, o, d, and w.
- The letters that are most commonly found at the ends of words are e, s, d, and t.
- The most common word endings are -ed, -ing, -ion, -ist, -ous, -ent, -able, -ment, -tion, -ight, and -ance.
- The most frequent double-letter combinations are ee, ll, ss, oo, tt, ff, rr, nn, pp, and cc.
- The double letters that occur most commonly at the end of words are ee, ll, ss, and ff.
- Two letters that usually follow an apostrophe are t and s.
- The title of the cryptic cluster gives the most useful clue. Make a list of words or phrases associated with this title. Study the letter patterns among these words and try to match them with the patterns in the encrypted words. (For example, if the title of a cryptic cluster is "Birthday Party", FGKKXXP is probably an encryption of BALLOON because of the pattern of two doubled letters coming next to each other.)

### Hints:

The answer to the first word is "Honest." Inside the list is another answer, "Broad-minded."

**Solution:**

HONEST

FORWARD-LOOKING

INSPIRING

COMPETENT

FAIR-MINDED

SUPPORTIVE

BROAD-MINDED

INTELLIGENT

STRAIGHTFORWARD

DEPENDABLE, COURAGEOUS